MAINE

The Pine Tree State



Maine has never needed much convincing when it comes to lobster. The cold, dark waters of the Gulf of Maine—stretching from Kittery in the south to the rocky Canadian border—have produced some of the world's most prized lobster for thousands of years. The Wabanaki people, who inhabited the Maine coast long before European contact, harvested lobster so abundantly that early accounts described them washing ashore in piles two feet deep. For the Wabanaki, lobster was sustenance, practical and plentiful. The settlers who followed, however, initially wanted nothing to do with it. In the 1600s and 1700s, lobster was considered poor man's food—fed to prisoners, servants, and indentured workers so routinely that some colonial labor contracts reportedly included clauses limiting how often it could be served.

That reputation began to shift in the mid-1800s, when the railroad connected the Maine coast to the appetite of Boston and New York. Wealthy summer visitors—the people who would come to be called "rusticators"—arrived in places like Bar Harbor, Boothbay Harbor, and Camden, enchanted by the rugged landscape and the extraordinary seafood that came with it. Suddenly lobster was fashionable. Canneries opened along the coast, and by the late 19th century, Maine lobster was being shipped in tins across the country. The fishermen who had worked these waters for generations watched the world catch up to what they had always known.

The lobster roll itself is widely credited to a Connecticut restaurant, but it was along the Maine coast where the dish truly found its soul. Maine lobstermen and the small shoreside shacks that served them had little patience for complication. A steamed lobster, cracked and pulled, tucked into a split-top hot dog bun with nothing more than a brush of butter or a light hand with mayonnaise—that was the Maine version, and it remains the standard against which all others are measured. Places like Red's Eats in Wiscasset, which opened in 1938, became legendary for piling a full pound of lobster meat into a single bun, drawing lines of summer visitors stretching down the sidewalk and around the block. The dish became as much a part of the Maine summer experience as the smell of low tide and the sound of a lobster boat engine turning over at dawn.

What makes the Maine lobster roll endure is its honesty. It doesn't hide behind heavy seasoning or complicated technique. It asks only that the ingredients be exceptional—and along the Maine coast, they always are. When you make this dish, you are pulling from a tradition stretching back centuries, from Wabanaki shores to weathered fish shacks to your own kitchen. Use the sweetest lobster you can find, keep your hand light, and don't overthink it. The first bite will take you straight to the coast—salt air, cold water, and the particular joy of eating something that needs absolutely nothing added to be perfect.

LOBSTER ROLL

The briny sweetness of a perfectly made lobster roll—piled high in a buttered, toasted bun—is one of summer's most unapologetic pleasures.

Yield: 4 rolls

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb. cooked fresh Maine lobster meat, roughly chopped into ½–¾-inch pieces (knuckle and claw meat are ideal)
- ¼–⅓ cup good-quality mayonnaise such as Duke's (start with less and add to your preference)
- 1 small celery stalk, finely diced (optional, for a little crunch)
- 1 Tbsp fresh lemon juice (optional, for brightness)
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- 4 New England-style split-top hot dog buns
- 2–4 Tbsp unsalted butter, softened
- Lemon wedges, for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prepare the lobster salad*: In a medium bowl, gently combine the chopped lobster meat, mayonnaise, diced celery (if using), and lemon juice (if using). Season lightly with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Be mindful that the lobster is naturally slightly salty. Mix just enough mayonnaise to coat the lobster without making it too saucy. You want the chunks of lobster to remain prominent.
2. *Chill the lobster salad*: Cover the bowl and refrigerate for at least 15 minutes to allow the flavors to meld and the lobster to chill thoroughly. This step is crucial for the best texture and taste.
3. *Toast the buns*: Butter the sides of the buns. Toast in a skillet until golden brown.
4. *Assemble the rolls*: Fill each toasted bun with the lobster salad mixture.
5. *Serve*: Serve immediately with lemon wedges on the side, if desired. Pair with potato chips, fries, or creamy coleslaw. For the ultimate Maine experience, serve with a cup of clam chowder.

